Digital Social Work Practice learner guide

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Use digital tools and digital service channels in ways that advance access, protect privacy, and preserve accountable human professional judgement.

Use the laws, professional scope, organisational policies and approved referral routes that apply to your setting. This course is educational and does not replace urgent safeguarding, clinical or legal procedures. All worked cases are fictional. Research notes distinguish published findings from SWEEP teaching examples.

How to use this guide

Read each lesson, explain the worked example in your own words and complete its activity before checking the feedback. The decision points cover the concepts assessed; they are not a substitute for the explanations. Use the separate worksheet to integrate the three lessons. Study time depends on discussion and local adaptation, not a guaranteed completion duration.

Practice case

A neighbourhood advice service wants to replace its walk-in queue with a web booking system. Some residents use library computers, some need audio instructions, and others work shifts. Staff want to use automated summaries to reduce paperwork. Design a service pathway that preserves access, privacy and accountable decisions.

Module 1 Digital inclusion and service design

Choose an accessible service route with the person, based on their access, preferences, privacy and support needs.

Design the whole service journey

Digital inclusion concerns whether someone can obtain the intended support, not simply whether a website loads. Map discovery, booking, the appointment and follow-up as separate tasks. Ask the person which steps they can use privately, reliably and affordably. A person may manage text well but find a video call inaccessible; another may prefer remote access because travel is difficult. Offer choices without requiring people to justify a stereotype about their age or disability.

Test a realistic task before widening use. Invite willing users with different access needs, explain the test and avoid collecting real case histories. Notice where they stop or need help. A usable alternative should lead to the same service opportunity within a reasonable local timetable. Record only proportionate access information. Compare completion and abandonment across routes, and ask people who did not finish what prevented them. A higher login count alone cannot show that residents received support.

Worked example

Fictional worked example: the advice service's booking page times out at the library. The team tests a save-and-return option and a staff-assisted booking route with willing residents. It tracks successful bookings and reports of difficulty, without recording their private histories in the test log.

Decision points

A shared phone can create access and privacy barriers even when a person technically owns or borrows a device.

Test a proposed channel with people affected by access barriers before scaling it; a staff-only test misses real usage conditions.

An alternative route should provide a comparable opportunity to use a service, not a punitive or indefinitely delayed option.

Ask about functional access needs instead of inferring digital ability from age, disability or education.

Measure service completion and abandonment by route, using proportionate data and user feedback; logins alone do not demonstrate inclusion.

Apply the lesson

Draw two booking routes for the service. Identify one barrier at each step and propose a way to test it without using identifiable case material.

Check your reasoning

A strong response preserves resident choice, tests actual tasks, gives the assisted route a comparable opportunity, and names both a completion measure and a feedback method.

Module 2 Information governance and secure practice

Design a proportionate information-handling plan and identify when local governance advice is required.

Make an information handling plan

Start with the task and justify each field. A booking form needs enough information to arrange contact; it does not automatically need a detailed account of the person's circumstances. For each information item, identify its purpose, authorised viewers, storage location, sharing route and applicable retention decision. Refer uncertain legal grounds or retention questions to the responsible local lead. Do not infer that a signed form authorises every future use.

Explain communication choices in language the person understands and check any expressed uncertainty. Before sharing, confirm both the recipient and the necessary contents: an approved system can still send information to the wrong person. If an incident is suspected, use the organisation's reporting route promptly, preserve relevant facts and follow authorised containment instructions. Do not hide the incident or invent a notification deadline. The privacy lead must determine the applicable duties and exceptions.

Worked example

Fictional worked example: the booking team removes a required family-history field. It keeps a preferred contact route and practical access needs, restricts staff access by role, and asks its governance lead to approve the retention schedule before launch.

Decision points

Before collecting information, specify its purpose, who needs it, how it is protected and which locally approved retention rules apply.

Consent discussions should explain the channel's use, foreseeable privacy limitations and available alternatives in understandable language.

An approved channel must still be used appropriately: check the intended recipient and share only necessary information.

A suspected information incident needs prompt action through the organisation's incident route; preserve relevant facts and follow containment instructions.

Retention periods and exceptions require applicable policy and legal review; neither indefinite retention nor immediate deletion is a universal rule.

Apply the lesson

Write a five-field information register for booking. For each field give the purpose and authorised audience; mark any retention or legal question for local review.

Check your reasoning

Necessary booking information is separated from casework records. The answer states who must resolve uncertain rules and explains recipient checks and the incident-reporting route.

Module 3 Telepractice AI and professional accountability

Recognise unsuitable digital practice and maintain accountable human judgement when using AI assistance.

Keep professional judgement accountable

A remote appointment is a service arrangement, not just a connection. Check whether the setting and channel are suitable, explain relevant privacy limits and agree what happens if the connection fails. Use approved local procedures for urgent concerns; a remote session must not become a reason to delay required action. Revisit suitability when circumstances change.

Treat an automated summary as a draft that may contain unsupported statements or omit relevant context. Use only an authorised workflow for sensitive information, compare the draft with verified records and document substantive corrections. Partial name removal may leave a person identifiable through other details. Before relying on automated prioritisation, examine errors and who could be disadvantaged, not only average performance. Record the reasons for the professional decision and the advice sought. The worker's responsibility is not transferred to a tool.

Worked example

Fictional worked example: an authorised summarisation tool changes 'requested information about a referral' into 'referral completed'. The worker checks the source notes, corrects the draft, records the correction and raises the recurrent error with the service lead before wider use.

Decision points

Telepractice needs a suitability and privacy check plus an agreed response to connection loss or urgent concerns, adapted to the service and local procedures.

Check AI-generated statements against reliable case information; an AI draft is not a verified record or an accountable decision-maker.

Do not enter identifiable case material into an unapproved AI service; use authorised tools and information-governance procedures.

Review differential effects and error patterns before relying on an automated recommendation; average performance can hide exclusion.

A professional should be able to explain and document the reasons for a decision, including how an AI suggestion was checked and when advice was sought.

Apply the lesson

Write a verification checklist for an automated appointment summary, and a fallback plan for an unsuitable or disconnected remote appointment.

Check your reasoning

The checklist verifies statements against sources, checks omissions, protects case information, identifies a responsible human and defines a safe local fallback.

Assessment preparation

Explain the reasons behind each decision point. Practise with the worksheet using a different situation from the worked examples. The proposed assessment has 15 single-answer questions and a 70% pass threshold, requiring at least 11 correct whole-mark answers. Published settings and availability must be verified in the learning platform; this guide does not establish an assessment ID or certify completion.

Sources and evidence limits

[R1] Kvakic, M., and Larsson, K. K. (2024). Caseworkers on the digital streets: Discretion in the digital decision-making process. Journal of Comparative Social Work, 19(1), 13-40. https://doi.org/10.31265/jcsw.v19i1.624

Use in this course: Focus groups with 26 Norwegian child-welfare caseworkers identified digital decision points requiring professional discretion. Limit: Context-specific qualitative findings; not a test of AI accuracy or proof of effects in another country.

[S1] NASW and ASWB. Standards for Technology in Social Work Practice. https://www.socialworkers.org/Practice/NASW-Practice-Standards-Guidelines/Standards-for-Technology-in-Social-Work-Practice

Use in this course: Professional practice framework for technology use. Limit: Not a statement of Nigerian or other local law.

[S4] IFSW (2018). Global Social Work Statement of Ethical Principles. https://www.ifsw.org/global-social-work-statement-of-ethical-principles/

Use in this course: Dignity, participation, confidentiality and professional accountability. Limit: Does not replace applicable law or organisational safeguarding procedures.

The index record is a discovery aid, not a guarantee of quality. Read the source before applying its findings to a different setting. No article endorses this course.